The world is indeed very different, but its fundamentals have not been completely overturned. It is certainly true that Asia has risen impressively, and that the West has yielded space economically and politically. But to discount the West – Europe, leave alone the US – would be serious folly. And to suggest that growing Asian GDPs would translate themselves quickly into strategic influence is delusional. Such economic determinism may be an effective motivational exercise, but cannot serve as a basis for policymaking. The fact is that right now, the major markets are still in the West, as in fact is the capital needed for growth. More importantly, the West continues be the main source of technology and innovation, even if its leads are eroding. Global institutions are anchored in its mores as standards are largely set there. The global commons are largely regulated by the West and its invisible influence is perhaps even more potent than its visible form.

Declarations of its impending demise, therefore, are premature, to say the least. The military balance brings out this reality even more sharply. Defence budgets of the world are heavily dominated by Western expenditure, even if one excludes the US. And consider the wars fought in the last twenty-five years: Yugoslavia, Afghanistan, Iraq, Libya and Syria. Whatever their causes or results, all of them have seen a Western will to use force, great improvements in technology and its application, and a pronounced ability to apply political pressure. The US and Europe still remain the leading suppliers of military and dual-use technologies. Large parts of the world have a Western presence and they are often early responders when their interests are involved. And not coincidentally, they are the principal intermediaries in any regional negotiation.

When making a case for understanding with the West, there are understandably arguments of caution in India that reflect our difficult history. More recent developments like Iraq in 2003 and Afghanistan after 1979 are also factors, as indeed are memories of Western actions in our immediate neighbourhood. But as India rises in a more structurally loose world, this is increasingly a legacy issue. Concerns emanate from an era when India was weaker and the gap with the West much greater. Other nations were the poles of the world order and our task was to manage them with the least damage. What may have held true in the 1950s, when India chose to be non-aligned, is perhaps less so today. Maintaining that the risks